

Flock camera debate turns political in Ardmore

Kendall Timms, KTEN News

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ARDMORE, Okla. (KTEN) — Flock cameras have generated controversy in Ardmore.

After three city commissioners voted to keep the license plate readers around, the commissioner who voted “no” has other plans.

"The biggest beef is that they didn't allow any of the citizens to really express opposition to these cameras," said Jason May, an attorney who is backing a petition to remove four commissioners from office — the three who voted “yes” to renew the Flock camera contract, which began in 2024, and the commissioner who was not present for the vote.

"I'm concerned about how the city commissioners shut down the discussion on it," said Paula Colbert, who signed the petition. "I think we need to be more transparent."

At-large Commissioner Buddy Simon explained that during the meeting to renew the Flock contract, he raised questions on behalf of the people he represents about Flock's data privacy policies.

"It doesn't matter what my position about Flock is — whether I love it or hate it — it's what my constituents want," Simon said. "I know overwhelmingly that the constituents of this city do not want Flock."

Simon said while he was in the middle of asking questions, one commissioner motioned to vote on the contract renewal.

"Instantaneously, the mayor seconded the motion," Simon recalled. "When that happens, no more questions."

That action sparked the petition.

"This is a very loud voice that is coming out in our city, because they feel like their voice is not being heard," Simon said.

Acting City Manager Shawn Geurin told KTEN that the Oklahoma Open Meetings Act does not require public comment at meetings unless it is on the agenda.

"These meetings are strictly business meetings to do the city's business in an open forum," Geurin said.

He added that communication to commissioners can be done via emails, phone calls or letters.

The petition process to remove four city commissioners is in phase one, requiring 100 signatures for each member.

"We're way past 100 signatures already," May said.

After that, all four petitions need just over 1,000 signatures to take the recall to a vote in a special election.

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